First Aid Fundamentals
Basic First Aid Principles
First aid is the immediate care given to a person who has been injured or suddenly becomes ill. The goals of first aid are to preserve life, prevent the condition from worsening, and promote recovery.
The ABCs of First Aid
- **A · Airway**: Ensure the person's airway is clear
- **B · Breathing**: Check if the person is breathing
- **C · Circulation**: Check for pulse and control severe bleeding
General First Aid Steps
1. Assess the situation for safety
2. Call emergency services if needed
3. Provide care within your training level
4. Stay with the person until help arrives
5. Do not move a seriously injured person unless they are in immediate danger
Source: American Red Cross, WHO
Common First Aid Situations
Minor Cuts and Wounds
1. Wash your hands before treating the wound
2. Apply gentle pressure with a clean cloth to stop bleeding
3. Clean the wound with clean water
4. Apply an antibiotic ointment if available
5. Cover with a sterile bandage or adhesive bandage
6. Change the bandage daily or when it becomes wet or dirty
When to seek medical care:
- Deep cuts that may need stitches
- Wounds that won't stop bleeding after 10 minutes of pressure
- Wounds caused by animal bites
- Signs of infection: redness, swelling, warmth, pus, or fever
Burns
Minor burns (first-degree · redness, no blisters):
1. Cool the burn under cool (not cold) running water for 10-20 minutes
2. Do NOT apply ice, butter, or toothpaste
3. Cover with a sterile, non-stick bandage
4. Take over-the-counter pain relief if needed
More serious burns (second-degree · blisters; third-degree · white/charred):
1. Call emergency services
2. Do NOT remove clothing stuck to the burn
3. Cover loosely with a clean, dry cloth
4. Do NOT break blisters
5. Keep the person warm and comfortable until help arrives
Source: Mayo Clinic, American Red Cross
Sprains and Strains
Follow the **RICE method**:
- **R · Rest**: Avoid using the injured area
- **I · Ice**: Apply ice wrapped in a cloth for 15-20 minutes every 2-3 hours
- **C · Compression**: Wrap with an elastic bandage (not too tight)
- **E · Elevation**: Raise the injured area above heart level if possible
When to seek medical care:
- Inability to bear weight or use the joint
- Severe swelling or deformity
- Numbness in the injured area
- No improvement after 2-3 days of home care
Source: NIH, American Academy of Orthopaedic Surgeons
Choking (Heimlich Maneuver)
For conscious adults and children over 1 year:
1. Stand behind the person and wrap your arms around their waist
2. Make a fist with one hand and place it just above the navel

3. Grasp your fist with the other hand
4. Give quick, upward thrusts
5. Repeat until the object is expelled or the person becomes unconscious
6. If the person becomes unconscious, call emergency services and begin CPR
For infants under 1 year:
1. Place the infant face-down on your forearm, supporting the head
2. Give 5 firm back blows between the shoulder blades
3. Turn the infant face-up and give 5 chest thrusts
4. Repeat until the object is expelled or the infant becomes unresponsive
5. Call emergency services immediately
Source: American Red Cross, American Heart Association
Nosebleeds
1. Sit upright and lean slightly forward (NOT backward)
2. Pinch the soft part of the nose firmly
3. Hold for 10-15 minutes without checking
4. Breathe through your mouth
5. Apply a cold compress to the bridge of the nose
When to seek medical care:
- Bleeding lasts more than 20 minutes
- Nosebleed after a head injury
- Frequent recurring nosebleeds
- Heavy blood flow
Source: Mayo Clinic, NIH
Allergic Reactions
Mild allergic reactions:
- Take an antihistamine as directed
- Apply cool compresses to itchy areas
- Avoid the known allergen
- Monitor for worsening symptoms
Severe allergic reactions (Anaphylaxis) · EMERGENCY:
Signs: difficulty breathing, swelling of face/throat, rapid pulse, dizziness, nausea
1. Call emergency services (911/112) immediately
2. Use an epinephrine auto-injector (EpiPen) if available
3. Have the person lie down with legs elevated (unless breathing is difficult)
4. Loosen tight clothing
5. Begin CPR if the person stops breathing
6. Do NOT give oral medications if the person is having difficulty swallowing
Source: American Academy of Allergy, Asthma & Immunology, Mayo Clinic
When to Call Emergency Services
Always call emergency services (911 in the US, 112 in the EU, local emergency number) for:
- Chest pain or difficulty breathing
- Signs of stroke (FAST: Face drooping, Arm weakness, Speech difficulty, Time to call)
- Severe bleeding that won't stop
- Suspected broken bones, especially hip, pelvis, or femur
- Loss of consciousness
- Seizures lasting more than 5 minutes
- Severe allergic reactions (anaphylaxis)
- Suspected poisoning or overdose
- Severe burns
- Near-drowning
- Head, neck, or spine injuries
Source: American Red Cross, CDC, WHO